Bhaker had already starred in one such tragedy: at Tokyo 2020, both her pistol and her poise betrayed her. Returning empty-handed, facing a volley of sarcastic gunfire, and most of all haunted by her own sense of failure, she almost gave up on shooting. Never mind that she was all of 19 and had already accomplished a lot in the international arena. Failure to turn up for the big occasion has unravelled many a bright star. But not Manu. After healing her bruises with a touch of spiritual recouping, she decided she was in no mood to be remembered as the girl who missed.

The Manu who headed to Chateauroux, France, was a markedly new, internally recomposed person. Here was a 22-year-old woman who possessed nerves of steel, a no-nonsense mind, and unstinting help from personal coach Jaspal Rana. About a month of training and acclimatisation at allied ranges preceded the pivotal qualification stage. When the curtains drew back, the world saw a shooter with the accuracy of a grizzled hitman in a Hollywood spy caper. The lethal combination hit bull's eye once, then a second time. She became India's first female shooter to ever win an Olympic medal. Her two bronzes—one solo, one teaming up with Sarabjot Singh in the mixed team 10m air pistol event—buoyed the spirits of a nation that had become accustomed to seeing its athletes come close to the Olympic podium, only to falter at the finish line. In fact, Manu almost gave them three cheers, coming agonisingly close to a bronze in 25m solo.

What makes her story worthy of a biopic—one in which she can conceivably play herself someday—is the classic narrative theme of a near-breakdown followed by an inspirational comeback against all odds. The dramatic elements of conflict and glorious resolution are all there—a protagonist who identifies her frailties and works on them, and who recognises that the only person who can bring the best out of her is the very guru (Rana) who had aggrieved her a few years back. She extends him the olive branch and, after a year or so of being upstaged by younger compatriots, sweeps the field at crunch hour—the national trials for the Olympics. Supporting characters include a mother who battles patriarchy and demands discipline from her kids and a doting father who is away at sea as a merchant navy engineer but happily funds his talented daughter's passion. A climax in Paris, under the world's gaze, tops it—at least for now.

In her personal life, Manu was empowered enough to convince her father to get an apartment close to the Karni Singh shooting range in Faridabad. Behind the stoic exterior usual in shooters is also a young woman who loves to shop, dress up and favours *ghar ka khaana* over eating out. She comes across as owning a maturity belying her age, fine-tuning her appearance on and off the range: she prefers muted make-up, but is serenely comfortable in the often blinding spotlight that has transformed her into a pin-up star for Indian sport. Or a "national crush", as some like to call her. After her Parisian exploits, she walked the ramp, posed for magazine covers and handled the myriad demands of nation-wide fame with an innate poise and balance.

In 2024, Manu scripted a classic turnaround. Like all the down-and-out protagonists of sports biopics, Manu couldn't have predicted the heights she would climb. The central scene captures that. In which, head held high, with rousing orchestral music playing in the background, she carries the Indian flag at the closing ceremony of the Olympics. ■

Right On Target

- **In the Paris Olympics, Manu Bhaker won two bronze medals—one in the individual 10m air pistol event, and another in the 10m air pistol mixed team event with Sarabjot Singh**
- **She became the first Indian female shooter to win an Olympic medal**
- **She is also the only Indian athlete, male or female, to win two medals in a single Olympic games**
- **When not training/competing, Manu loves to go horse-riding, solve puzzles, dance, work out, go for a run or go on a drive with friends**

Manu speaks with a maturity that belies her age, and is serenely confident in the spotlight that has transformed her into a pin-up for Indian sport